Lene Hansen, *Theorizing the image of Security Studies*: European Journal of International Relations 2011 17, 19 January, 2011;

Steve Smith, *Singing Our World into Existence: International Relations Theory and September 11*, Presidential address to International Studies Association, February 27, 2003.

The two articles are not contextually related although they both deal with what one would define as non-traditional or emerging trends and issues in the disciplines of International Relation and Security studies. Lene Hansen's article focuses on visual imagery (photos, videos and somewhat separately political cartoons) as an agent of Securitization. This, in my opinion is a worthwhile topic for more intensive study, in view of the rapid developments and advancements of "imagery technology", especially video streaming, Computer Generated Graphics (CGI) and Virtual Reality. The aforementioned disciplines have been traditionally and almost exclusively textual with imagery introduced to accentuate a narrative. Such imagery was of the more symbolic (e.g. Swastikas) or iconic (e.g. Iwo Jima) nature or supportive of war and/or political journalism. The article is circa 2003 and considering the pace of technology, desperately begs to be updated. It offers in my opinion a well thought out and comprehensive theory analysis as to its (imagery) place and impact on concept of Securitization. However, the article if not neglects, glosses over some aspects of imagery that have been enabled by different technologies and which create some worrisome consequences. The most basic of considerations is the fact that human beings are conditioned to accept imagery as authentic reality, ("a picture never lies") and value-neutral documentary. As such the article places little emphasis on the aspect of manipulation and exploitation (political, ideological etc.) of imagery by altered reality technologies (filtering, "photo-shopping, pixel manipulation, video-editing and angle photography. In so doing it underestimates the power of the visual to (falsely) securitize by itself i.e. that the image does speak security by itself. Take for example this picture:



Is the soldier aiming his rifle at the woman's crotch or is he holding his rifle horizontally, or does it matter?

The second aspect is that of ethics and morality. Does publication of gruesome photos or videos of terror attacks constitute securitization?If so isthe state of Israel at an IR disadvantage for ethically forbidding such publication?

I disagree with Mitchel (2005:140) and Campbell (2004:62-63). Images are words. In fact didn't the Chinese teach us that a picture is worth a thousand words? Similarly, Hansen fails to acknowledge that today's imagery also involvesmediation and because of its real time implication may pre-empt the trailing written narrative by as much as a 180 degrees. This hazard (falsified or altered imagery) is further aggravated because, as Hansen herself points out, it transcends linguistic boundaries and its circulation is immediate and global. By contrast Hansen's analysis of the use of political cartooning as a securitization agent is thought provoking and original. Yet once again her treatment of the "Mohamed Cartoon Crisis" is too soft on the terrorizing elements of this incident and its violent consequences. It would seem that scholars may at times soften their stance on critical issues for academic acceptance of their study.

This is a perfect Segway to second article where Steven Smith addresses an urgent need for sole searching by the IR community as to it,heretofore, almost obsessive pursuit of "Rationalist Orthodoxy". I side with Weber when he says that " ...the true teacher will beware of imposing from the platform any political position upon the student (contrary to my experience at York University)...whenever the man of science introduces his personal value judgment, a full understanding of the facts ceases" (Weber 1948a: 145-146). However like in many other endeavors a careful balance is required and I am somewhat perturbed by the "overboard" scholastic trend of "third wave" normative, reflective theories. Once again however I find myself critical of Smith in his case study selection of September 11, which too many scholars have since that event chosen to position as backdrop to their own agenda, legitimate as it may be. I consider this to be a form of marketing gimmickry of which in this particular case (9/11) I do not approve. I am similarly skeptical possibly because of my Israeli background with Smith's advocacy of U.N.'s role in alleviating its documented long list of "human security". I agree that the U.S monopoly on IR in terms of its interests and values (owing mainly to its funding) has to be tempered. However there are few signs that the ROW is ready to pick up the slack.

Finally I was fascinated by Smith analysis of Art, Interpretation and Representation even though I failed to grasp the immediate relevancy to the rest of the article, other than by way of a metaphor for changing attitudes and paradigms in IR.

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